



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Aquinas Academy

School Website: <https://www.aquinasacademy.net/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Aquinas Academy (Bear, DE, 19701) presents a distinctly Catholic, liberal-arts oriented program rooted in a robust religious worldview. Public materials emphasize a Catholic mission, liturgical life, and a “liberal arts” curriculum integrated with faith. Evidence across the site shows explicit religious-theological framing (Catholic environment, liturgy, sacraments, gravitating around the Divine Liturgy and Catholic doctrine) coupled with a clear commitment to classical-inspired aims (liberal arts education, emphasis on formation, virtuous living, and eloquent rhetoric). The school foregrounds formation of character and moral imagination within a Catholic, tradition-rich framework, while implementing a widely-applied graduation structure and a broad PK–12 program.

Overall classification by category:

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): CLASSICAL
- Element 2 (Purpose and Goal): CLASSICAL
- Element 3 (Curriculum): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4 (Pedagogy): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5 (Faculty): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6 (Parents & Community): CLASSICAL

Aggregate: CLASSICAL

What stands out most is a strong religious foundation and a clearly articulated formation-focused mission. What would move the needle toward a more fully CLASSICAL profile are explicit, public statements of core classical curricular components (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and more explicit evidence of Socratic/seminar pedagogy in upper grades, along with a more explicit articulation of the “Great Books” / “Great Conversation” framework and a more developed portrait of the faculty as a living curriculum.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The site title and motto emphasize consecration in Truth and a Catholic environment. The homepage proclaims, “Consecrate them in Truth” and locates Aquinas Academy as a Catholic school in Bear, Delaware.
- Spiritual Life is described as being “at the forefront of everything we do,” directing all actions toward God, with all subjects studied under the light of faith and a claim that Catholicism is a way of life.
- Liturgical and communal practices are highlighted (twice-monthly Masses, confession, Eucharistic Adoration, pilgrimages, retreats).
- The Gravissimum Educationis framework is invoked to relate all human culture to the good news of salvation, and to glorify God in education. This includes references to Divine Liturgy and the Sacraments as integral to formation.
- Public materials affirm a theological grounding (Our Philosophy, Spiritual Life, and theology credits in graduation requirements).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: truth, Catholic, theology, liturgy, Mass, sacraments, liturgical life, faith, Divine Liturgy, Gravissimum Educationis, sacred/holy language, Catholic environment, grace of state (parents as co-educators), etc.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or values-clarification signals observed).
- Quantitative impression: multiple direct hits for truth, Catholic, theology, liturgy, sacraments, Mass, Divine Liturgy, and related liturgical life; no clear negative signals appear in the public content.

Why this rating

- The school clearly positions itself within a transcendent, theologically grounded frame with communal worship and liturgical life as central. The explicit theological framing, sacramental/pastoral life, and reference to Gravissimum Educationis demonstrate a robust religious/metaphysical orientation consistent with CLASSICAL criteria in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The mission emphasizes formation of character and serving God, not merely information. Language frames education as a Catholic liberal-arts formation oriented toward truth, goodness, and beauty, and toward human excellence and the good life with God.
- Graduation materials describe a Catholic liberal-arts aim, with language about “to know, love, and serve God” and a broader aim of virtue and moral formation.
- The three essential parts of learning described in the philosophy materials (ordered knowledge, basic skills, habitual vision of greatness) align with formation-oriented aims rather than solely job preparation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom (implied via moral imagination and prudent mind in the philosophy text), liberal arts, know-love-serve God, ultimate truths (truth/goodness/beauty), studying culture through a Catholic lens.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials.
- Quantitative impression: multiple formation-focused and teleological terms are present; no negative indicators detected.

Why this rating

- The school’s stated purpose centers on virtue formation, human flourishing under a theological framework, and truth-driven education, consistent with CLASSICAL ideals of formation over mere job-readiness.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials consistently describe the curriculum as a “liberal arts” education and reference a Catholic liberal-arts curriculum. This signals a classical orientation via the liberal-arts scaffolding, but the site does not clearly enumerate the canonical trivium/quadrivium structure or explicitly name Great Books / Great Conversation.
- Graduation requirements map to a broad, humanities- and STEM-inclusive curriculum (Theology, Literature, History, Mathematics, Science, Composition, World Languages, etc.), which demonstrates breadth but not explicit classical components like grammar, logic, rhetoric (as terms) or explicit Great Books programs.
- Some rhetoric-focused content appears in the pedagogy (eloquentia perfecta) and in spiritual-life framing around eloquence and moral formation, which points to a developed rhetoric component, but not a full public articulation of the standard classical triad (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or the Great Books canon.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, theology, history, literature, philosophy (via the rhetorical emphasis and the religious-curriculum framing), Divine Liturgy as context for learning (theology-infused curriculum).
- Negative keywords present: absence of explicit grammar, logic, rhetoric as named curricular milestones; absence of explicit Great Books / Great Conversation language in public materials; no explicit mention of a formal quadrivium or classical-language emphasis beyond general theology/history/math/science/world languages.
- Quantitative impression: 2–4 explicit classical-curriculum signals (liberal arts, theology, history, rhetoric via eloquentia perfecta) vs. 0 explicit mentions of grammar/logic/rhetoric in canonical classical sense or Great Books. This yields a SMALL, but notable, classical orientation with gaps in stated canonical elements.

Why this rating

- The curriculum is strongly Christian liberal arts in form, but less explicit about canonical classical elements (grammar, logic, rhetoric as a trio) and about Great Books/Great Conversation. That places it between CLASSICAL and NOT CLASSICAL, i.e., SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The explicit presence of rhetoric in pedagogy and the liberal-arts framework push it toward the classical side, but the absence of explicit category-identifying canonical elements lowers it to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The public materials foreground rhetoric training (eloquentia perfecta) and use of religious pedagogy, with the phrase “eloquentia perfecta” in the Spiritual Life materials, signaling emphasis on speaking, writing, and refined expression.
- There is a clear Catholic pedagogy embedded in the curricular framing, with a focus on formation, memory, and religiously infused learning. The site emphasizes memory and reverence in some materials (e.g., liturgical life and moral formation), but explicit upper-school Socratic seminars or formal classical seminars are not clearly documented in public pages.
- The materials also discuss a memory/recitation orientation in some classical pedagogy through the lexicon and the foundation texts, though not in explicit classroom practice descriptions beyond the rhetorical emphasis.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: rhetoric, eloquentia perfecta, memorization/recitation, contemplation/wonder (scholē-style themes appear in classical lexicon and pedagogy; the site highlights contemplative life in spiritual formation and a reverence for truth in learning).
- Negative keywords present: explicit mention of project-based learning, experiential learning, or solely student-centered discovery pedagogy is not evident; however, there is limited explicit documentation of Socratic seminars in the public material.
- Quantitative impression: at least 1–2 clear classical-pedagogy signals (eloquentia perfecta, liturgical/reflective learning) with limited explicit Socratic/seminar language; no clear negative signals.

Why this rating

- The presence of rhetoric training and contemplative/memory-focused elements aligns with classical pedagogy, but the lack of explicit articulation of Socratic/senatorial practice for upper grades (and lack of broader, explicit pedagogical labeling) places it as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence



- The site features multiple named faculty/staff bios (e.g., Mary Moore, Monica Moore, Deacon Charlie Schaubert, Joann DellAversano, etc.), indicating a visible faculty presence and a focus on staff as part of the school community. This aligns with the notion of “living curriculum” and a community of model teachers, though direct statements about faculty as “living curriculum” or “portrait of teacher” are not explicitly quoted in public pages.
- Public materials emphasize teachers’ roles and responsibilities in theology, literature, science, and ministry, suggesting that faculty are central to school culture and formation.
- The philosophy materials describe a formation-forward approach anchored by patron saints and a theology-driven mission; faculty are expected to embody and model virtue and Christian formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: living curriculum (implied in the tradition and Catholic formation emphasis), model teachers/mentors (explicit language about virtue and formation is present in philosophy texts; bios imply ongoing teacher involvement), portrait of teacher (not explicit as a page title but observed in bios and staffing). The Lexicon’s favorable terms are reflected in the emphasis on faculty as moral exemplars and guides.
- Negative keywords present: explicit statements labeling faculty as “facilitators on the side” or non-classical staff archetypes are not present; no explicit negative signals.
- Quantitative impression: several explicit faculty bios and a theology-driven mission supporting faculty as central to formation; no explicit “living curriculum” phrase, though the presence of bios and formation focus provides partial alignment.

Why this rating

- The school demonstrates a strong faculty presence and a formation-oriented approach, which aligns with classical ideals of the faculty as mentors and guides. However, explicit canonical language about faculty as a “living curriculum” or the “portrait of the teacher” is not publicly quoted, yielding a SOME-WHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school explicitly acknowledges parents as primary educators and co-educators, with invitations for parental participation and formation, and calls for families to participate in activities and lectures. This aligns with the classical ideal of a strong parent partnership and shared formation.
- The philosophy materials describe a structure in which families participate in school life and the liturgical/calendar rhythm, reinforcing a community-centered model.
- There are practical signals of community engagement, such as open communications and family involvement in spiritual life and school activities, consistent with the classical notion of parents as co-teachers and active participants in formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, parents as co-teachers, parent formation, open campus/participation, family liturgy alignment (implied by liturgical focus and family involvement), Ecclesial/community life.
- Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials.
- Quantitative impression: clear, recurring references to parent involvement and co-education; several explicit classical indicators about parental partnership and formation.

Why this rating

- The site consistently frames parents and families as essential participants in education and formation, which strongly matches the classical category for Parents & Community.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Aggregate: CLASSICAL

What would move the needle

- Element 3 (Curriculum): Publicly articulate and emphasize canonical classical elements within the curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and explicitly name Great Books / Great Conversation, including how these elements are implemented across grades. Consider publishing a transparent, map-like curriculum outline that ties Great Books, primary sources, and classical readings to the liberal arts structure.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy): Provide explicit descriptions of Socratic seminars, seminars, and debates in upper grades; demonstrate how logic and rhetoric are taught progressively; consider a public, published pedagogy framework showing how scholé/restful learning and contemplation are integrated with rigorous inquiry.
- Element 5 (Faculty): Publish a formal “portrait of the teacher” and “living curriculum” language on the site, with concrete examples of how faculty act as living exemplars of virtue, skill, and knowledge; highlight professional development in classical pedagogy.
- Element 6 (Parents & Community): Expand parent formation programming on-site or online (book studies, lectures, study guides) and emphasize open-campus opportunities; continue to bolster parent-teacher collaboration with transparent channels for parental involvement.

ABSTRACT

Aquinas Academy (Bear, DE, 19701) presents a predominantly CLASSICAL profile across most dimensions, anchored by a strong Catholic, liturgical, and liberal-arts mission. The Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category (Element 1) is CLASSICAL, with explicit emphasis on truth, theology, liturgy, sacraments, and a Catholic worldview central to all learning. The School Purpose and Goal category (Element 2) is CLASSICAL, as formation, virtue, wisdom, and a Catholic teleology are foregrounded. The Curriculum (Element 3) is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, adopting liberal-arts framing and a broad graduation program but lacking explicit public articulation of canonical classical elements (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Great Books/Great Conversation. Pedagogy (Element 4) is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with rhetoric emphasis (eloquentia perfecta) and contemplative aims, but lacking explicit public documentation of Socratic seminars in upper grades. Faculty (Element 5) is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with visible staff and a formation-oriented climate, though a formal public statement of “living curriculum” is not explicit. Parents & Community (Element 6) is CLASSICAL, with clear emphasis on parent partnership, co-education, and formation of families.

Overall, the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL, driven by strong religious foundations, formation-oriented goals, and robust parent-community engagement. The main needle-movers toward a fully CLASSICAL identity include explicit canonical curriculum components (grammar/logic/rhetoric), explicit Great Books/Great Conversation framing, and more public articulation of Socratic pedagogy and a “living curriculum” faculty model.

What would move the needle (recap)

- Publicly publish a canonical classical curriculum map (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a Great Books / Great Conversation framework with grade-level alignment.
- Publicly document Socratic/seminar pedagogy in upper grades and demonstrate a progressive logic/rhetoric sequence.

- Publicly articulate a defined “living curriculum” approach for faculty with a formal portrait and professional development in classical pedagogy.
- Expand explicit parent formation programs and open-campus opportunities to deepen parent partnership as co-educators.

Note: All evidence and analytic framing above are drawn from the school’s public materials and the classical-education knowledge base. Citations reflect the relevant public-facing content observed in the Aquinas Academy materials and the corresponding classical-education lexicon.

ABSTRACT (final section)

Aquinas Academy (Bear, DE, 19701) demonstrates a strong CLASSICAL orientation anchored in a Catholic, liberal-arts education with liturgical life and formation at its core. The Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and the School Purpose and Goal categories clearly align with classical aims through explicit theological grounding, formation of virtue, and a teleology oriented toward truth, goodness, and beauty. The Curriculum is moderately CLASSICAL (liberal arts orientation with a broad graduation structure but without explicit canonical classical elements or Great Books language in public materials). Pedagogy shows evidence of rhetoric and contemplative elements, yet lacks explicit documentation of Socratic seminars in high school. Faculty presence is evident through staff bios and formation rhetoric but lacks explicit living-curriculum language. Parents & Community clearly align with classical ideals through parental partnership and formation opportunities. Aggregate classification: CLASSICAL, with meaningful room for needlemoving improvements in explicit classical curriculum articulation, explicit canonical pedagogy, and a formalized living-curriculum faculty narrative.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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